Personalized Happiness: What Person-Specific Paradigms Offer Well-Being Science

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Outline

Why is the study of well-being aligned with person-specific paradigms?

How does a person-specific approach arbitrate competing theories of well-being?

How might well-being research move toward person-specificity?

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What is Well-Being?

Table 1 Commonly used definitions associated with emotional well-being of emotional well-being and related constructs reviewed in group discussions

Term	Definition	Source
Well-being (WB)	A top-down perspective on well-being, in which happy individuals are predicted to have more positive and adaptive responses to life events. Lyubomirsky has found that individuals that display positive well-being interpret situations and life events in ways that maintain (or promote) their general self-perception and sense of contentment	Lyubomirsky (2001)
WB	…no consensus…but general agreement that at minimum, (emotional) well-being includes the presence of positive emotions and moods (e.g., contentment, happiness), the absence of negative emotions (e.g., depression, anxiety), satisfaction with life, fulfillment and positive functioning. In simple terms, well-being can be described as judging life positively and feeling good	Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (2018)
SWB	People's overall evaluations of their lives and their emotional experiences. SWB thus includes broad appraisals, such as life satisfaction and health satisfaction judgments, and specific feelings that reflect how people are reacting to the events and circumstances in their lives	Diener et al., (2018)
SWB	… a cognition process of satisfaction or happiness, which is derived from optimal functioning. Can be classified into subjective vs. objective elements; subjective components involve personal and psychological factors such as belief system and contentment, and objective components involve external factors such as income, neighborhood safety, and community support	(Lindert et al., 2015)
SWB	… made up of somewhat independent elements, including positive and negative affect, and life satisfaction; these aspects should all be studied individually. It is defined as the evaluation one has on their life, therefore focuses on many variables such as self-perception, life experience, emotional reactions (Diener et al., 2003)	(Diener et al., 2018)
Subjective well-being (SWB)/ EWB (used interchangeably)	…refers to how people experience the quality of their lives and includes both emotional reactions and cognitive judgments. It has three components: (1) eudaimonia ((2) life satisfaction or evaluative well-being; and (3) hedonic or affectual or experiential well-being. SWB here is defined as synonymous with EWB	National Institutes of Health, (2018a)
EWB	Not synonymous with the absence of illness, nor synonymous with mental health. EWB… is an umbrella label for several related psychometrically defined concepts, including psychological well-being, positive mental health, health-related quality of life, thriving, and subjective well-being. These concepts encompass several psychological dimensions, including positive emotions and moods (e.g., happiness); the relative absence of negative emotions, moods, and states (e.g., stress, sadness, loneliness); life satisfaction; sense of meaning and purpose; quality of life; and satisfaction with other life domains (e.g., work satisfaction, satisfaction with relationships)	(Feller et al. and University of California Los Angeles Community Translational Science Team, 2018)
Flourishing	has five components: positive emotions, a general feeling of contentment; engagement, a state of flow in activities; relationships, a supportive and valuable support network; meaning, a sense of purpose; and accomplishment, a feeling of achievement	(Seligman, 2011)

Table 1 (continued)

Term	Definition	Source
Psychological well-being (PWB)	Six elements: • Autonomy—sense of individuality; self-evaluation based on personal standards rather than others • Personal growth—continuously developing and seeing potential in oneself • Self-acceptance—holding positive attitudes of oneself; a positive self-perception • Purpose in life—sense of direction and purpose within one's life • Positive relations with others—having good relationships with others; feeling capable of love and empathy • Environmental mastery—ability to choose environments that make one the most comfortable and secure	Ryff (1989)
EWB	Umbrella label for several related psychometrically defined concepts, including psychological well-being, positive mental health, health-related quality of life, thriving, and subjective well-being. The definition of EWB encompasses satisfaction with relationships, the subjective perception of social support. Also closely entwined are the structural aspects of social relationships (e.g., extent of social integration, size of social networks)	(Feller et al. and University of California Los Angeles Community Translational Science Team, 2018)
EWB	.. consists of three components: positive affect and negative affect (i.e., affective evaluations), and life satisfaction (i.e., cognitive evaluation)	Lyubomirsky and Lepper (1999)
EWB	…an overall positive state of one's emotions, life satisfaction, sense of meaning and purpose, and ability to pursue self-defined goals (Feller et al, 2018). Elements…include a sense of balance in emotion, thoughts, social relationships, and pursuits, or lack thereof. The relative importance of each construct will vary across subpopulations and developmental stages. Currently, fundamental consensus concerning the definition and components of emotional well-being, as well as what interventions promote emotional well-being, either as a mediator of health outcomes or as an end in itself, is lacking	National Institutes of Health, (2018b)
EWB	…feeling more of a pleasant effect (positive affect) than unpleasant effect (negative affect) in one's life overall, including past, present, and future perceptions (Reh et al., 2021)	(Reh et al., 2021)
EWB	People's positive moods and emotions and low levels of negative moods and emotions, and reflects not only momentary enjoyment, but also movement toward goals that are congruent with a person's motives	Fredrickson and Joiner (2002)

Park et al., 2022

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Well-being as an umbrella term

Well-being as defined by Its "Ingredients"

Well-being as a measure of functioning

Well-Being as an Umbrella

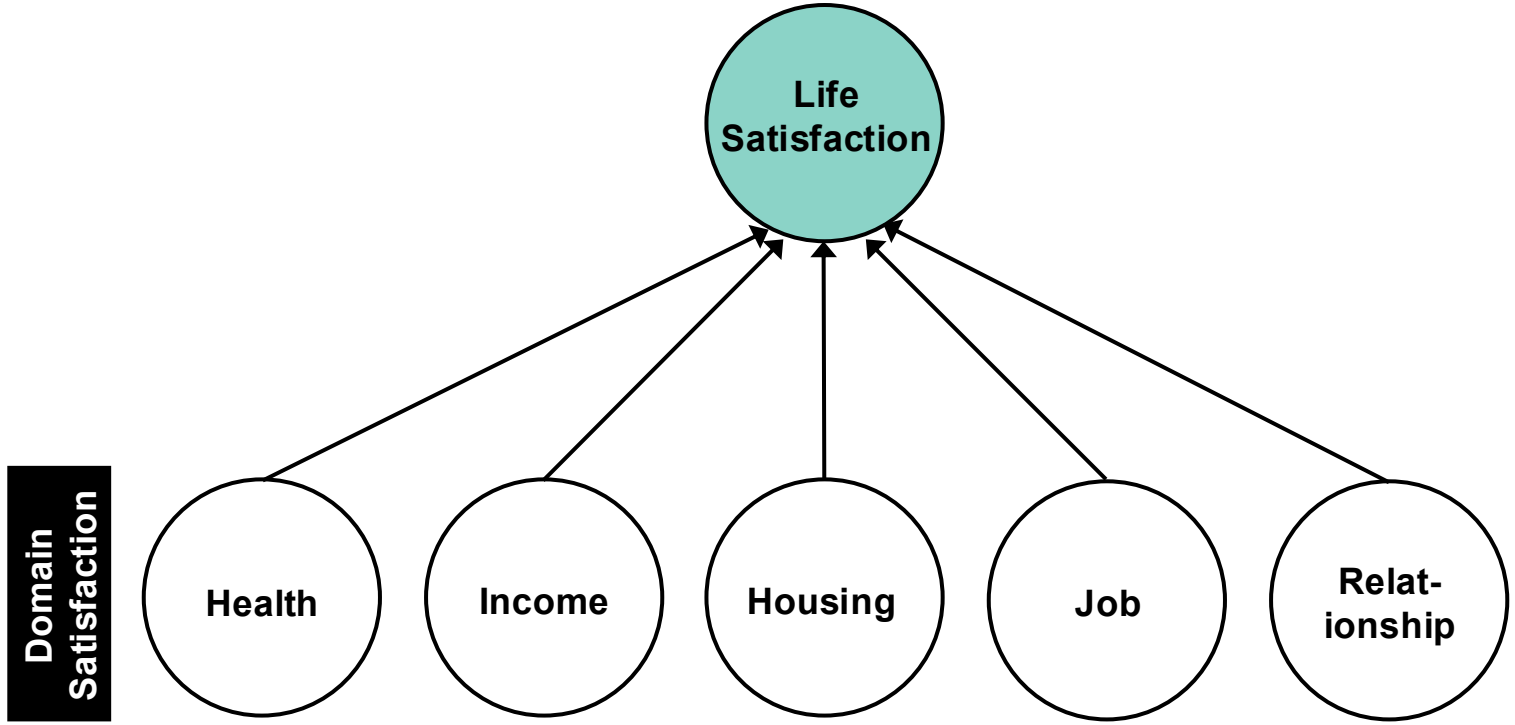
"EWB… is an **umbrella label** for several related psychometrically defined concepts, including psychological well-being, positive mental health, health-related quality of life, thriving, and subjective well-being."

National Institutes of Health, (2018a)

Generated with Microsoft Copilot

Well-Being as Ingredients

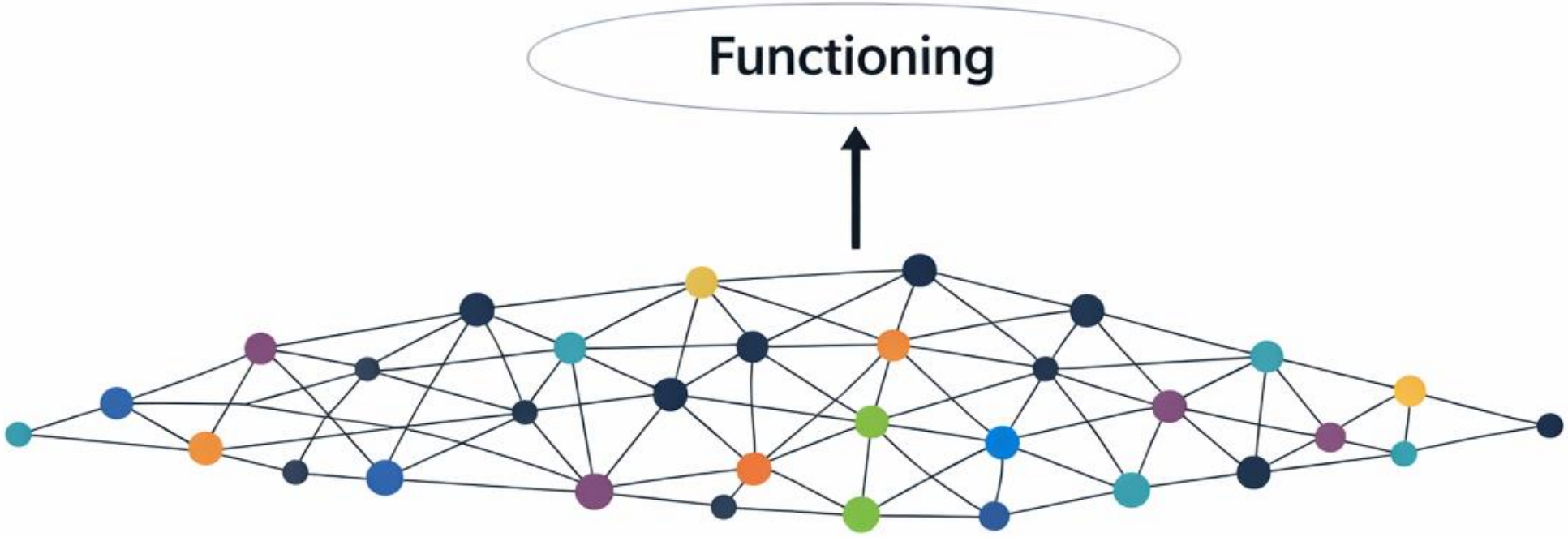
"**Elements**…include a sense of balance in emotion, thoughts, social relationships, and pursuits, or lack thereof. The **relative importance** of each construct will vary across subpopulations and developmental stages. Currently, fundamental consensus concerning the definition and **components**… is lacking"



National Institutes of Health, (2018b)

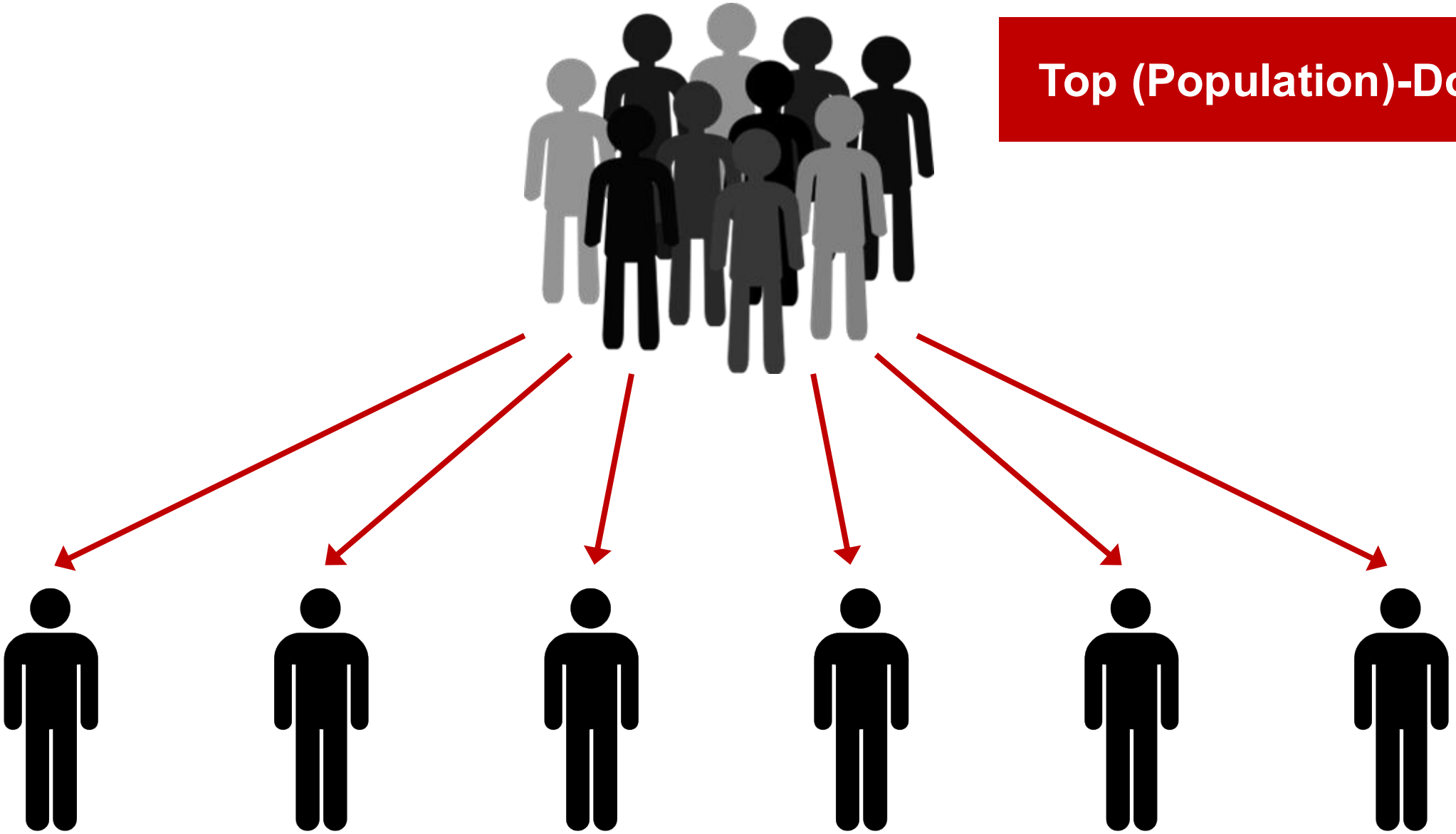
Well-Being as Functioning

"Wellbeing can be understood as how people feel and how they **function** both on a personal and social level, and how they evaluate their lives as a **whole.**"



Michaelson et al., 2012

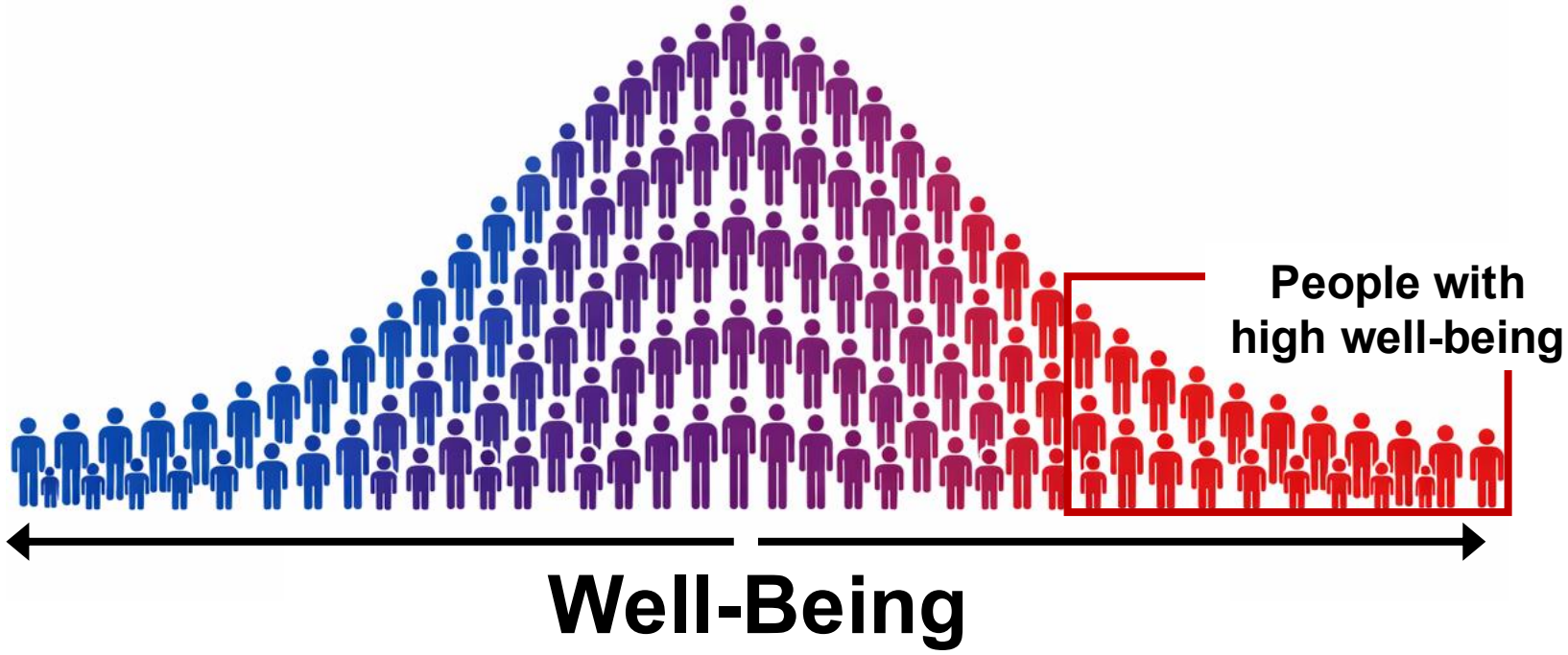
How do we understand and improve well-being?



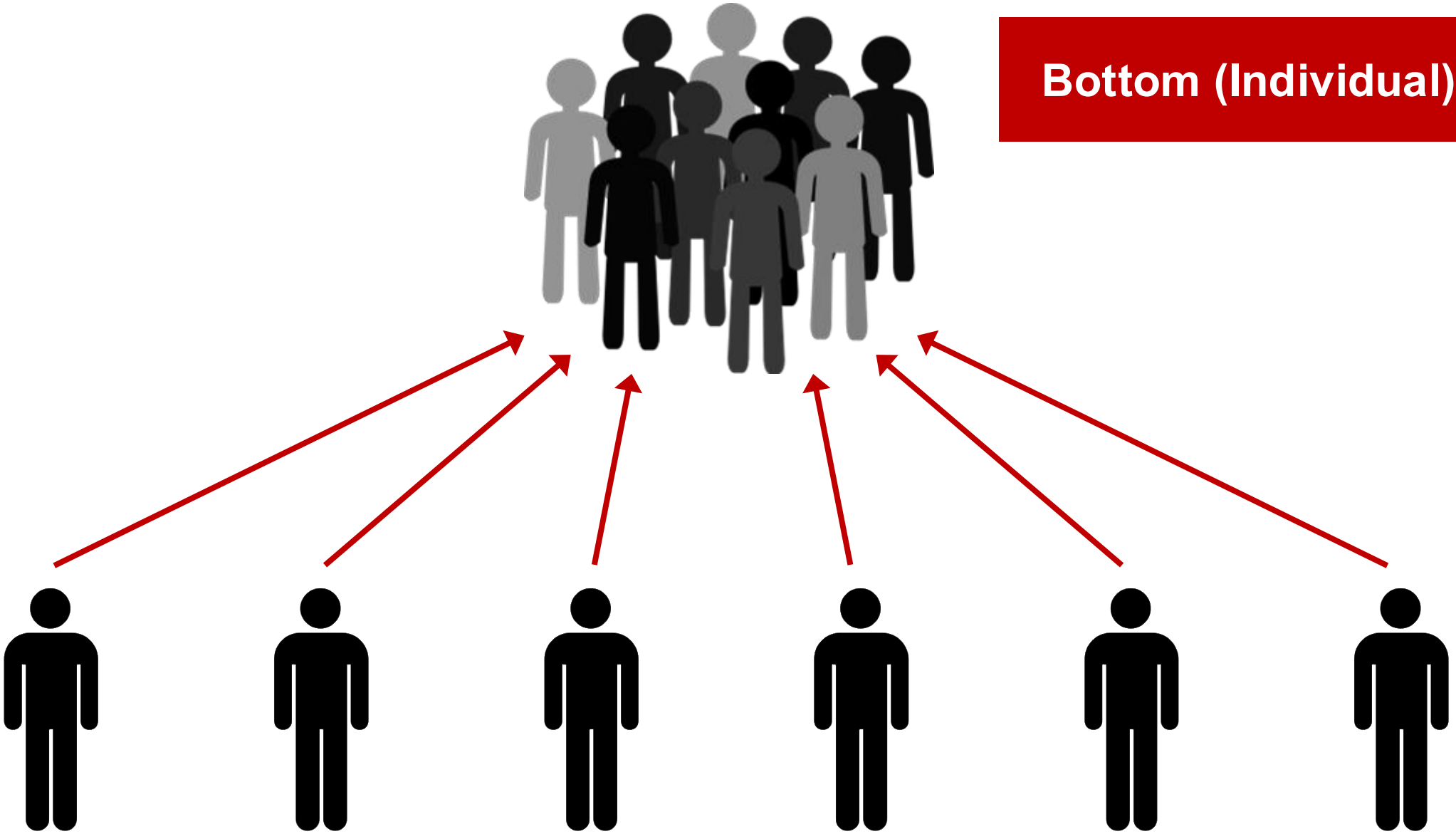
How do we improve well-being?

What do people with high well-being do?

What is *similar* about people with high well-being?



Bottom-Up Well-Being Science



Well-Being (and its determinants) is a property of a person, not a relative difference in a population

Social and Personality Psychology Compass

WILEY

ORIGINAL ARTICLE

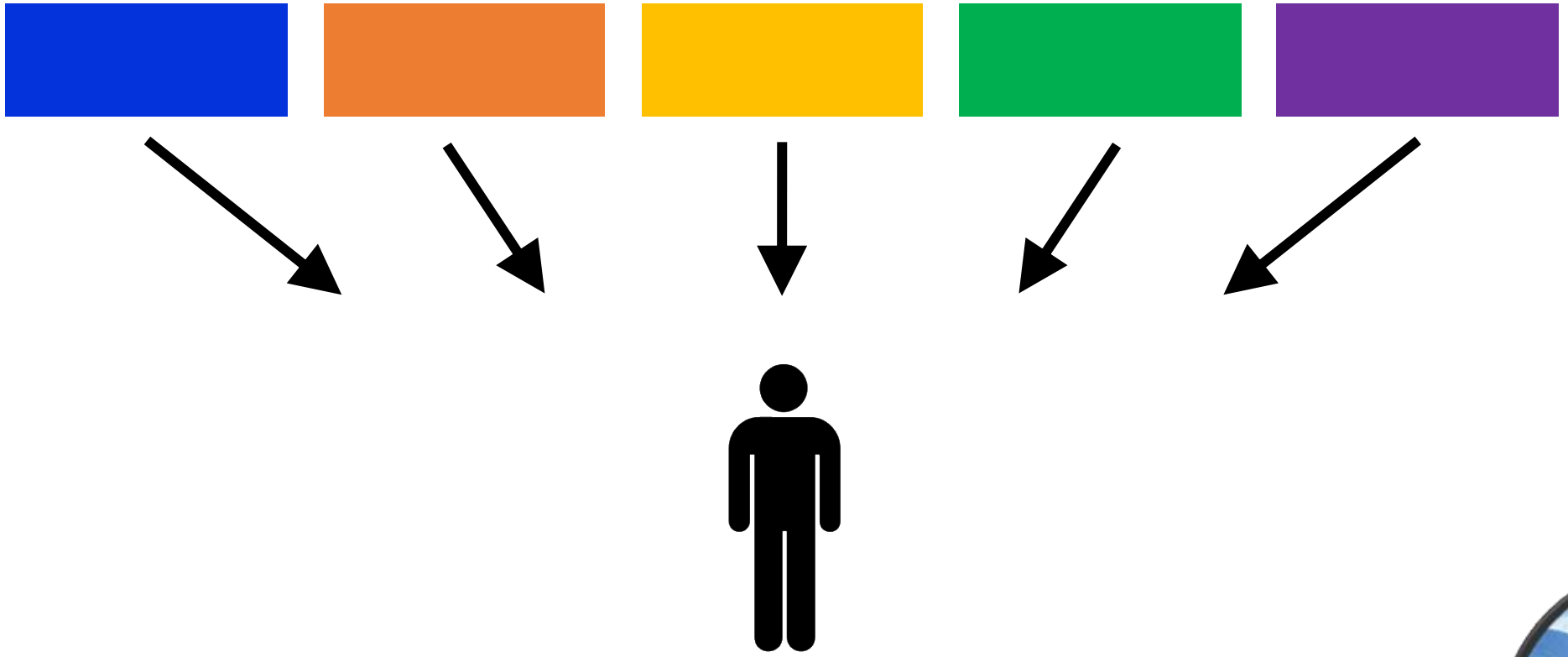
The Joy Is Mine: Re-Centering the Person in the Study of Well-Being

Adam T. Nissen | Emorie D. Beck

University of California, Davis, California, USA

Adam T. Nissen, PhD

People uniquely vary in their meaning-making processes (ingredients)

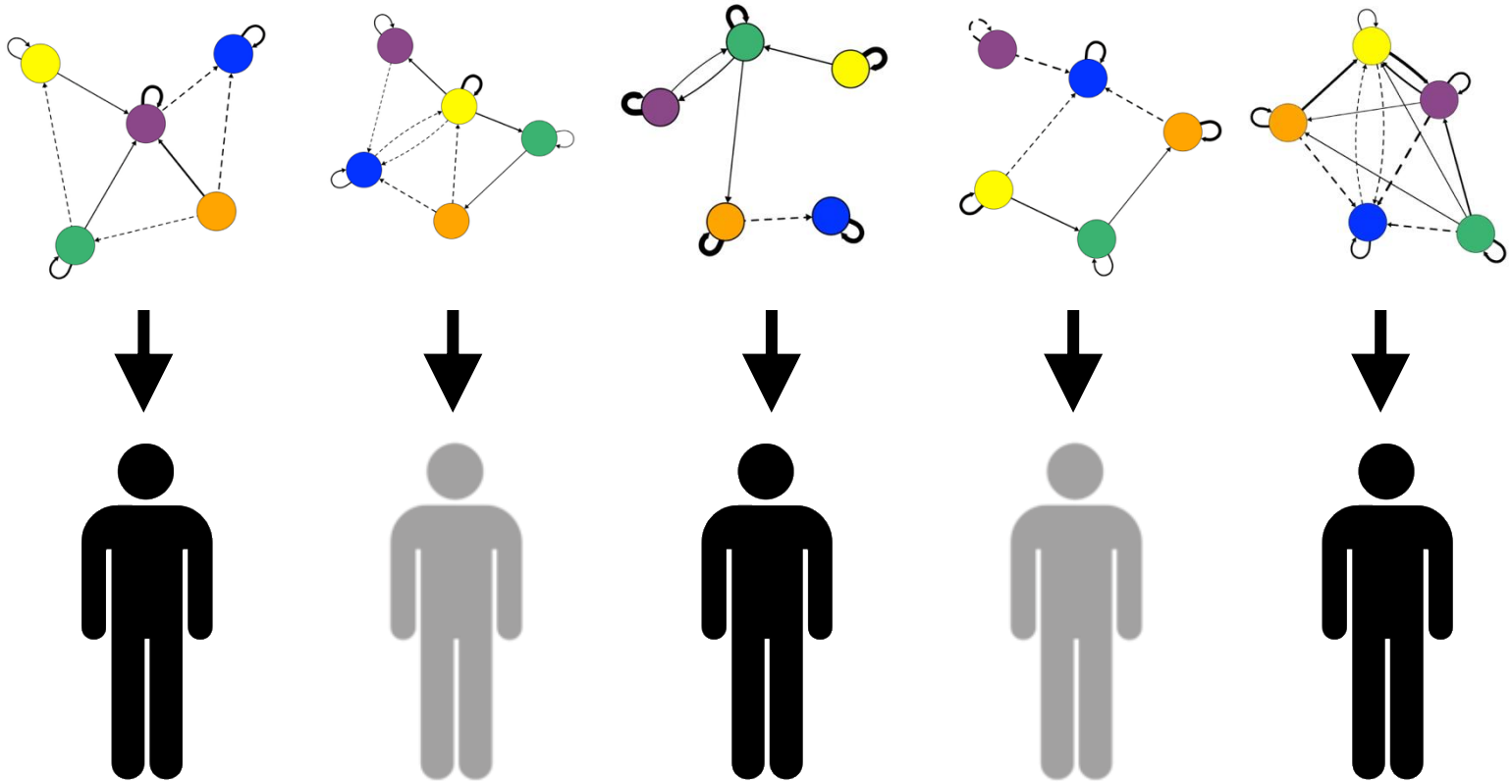


Idiographic
Person-Specific

Adam T. Nissen, PhD

e.g., Nissen & Beck, 2025; Beck & Jackson, 2020a

Well-Being is a person-specific dynamic system



Idiographic
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e.g., Nissen & Beck, 2025; Beck & Jackson, 2020a

Outline

Why is well-being aligned with person-specific paradigms?

Person-specific paradigms aim to capture the dynamics of the whole person, including unique ingredients, complex interactions, and emergent properties that align well with definitions of well-being

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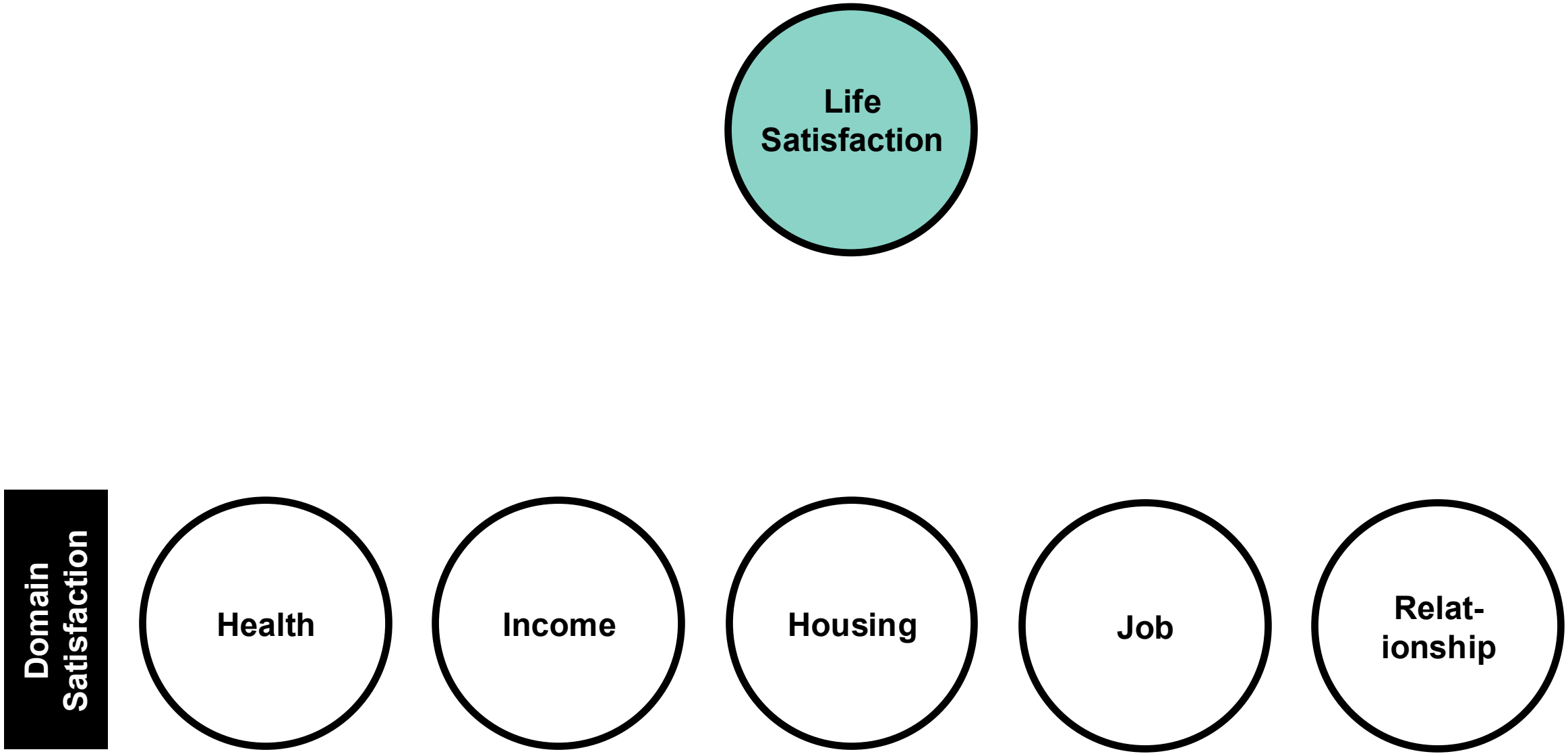
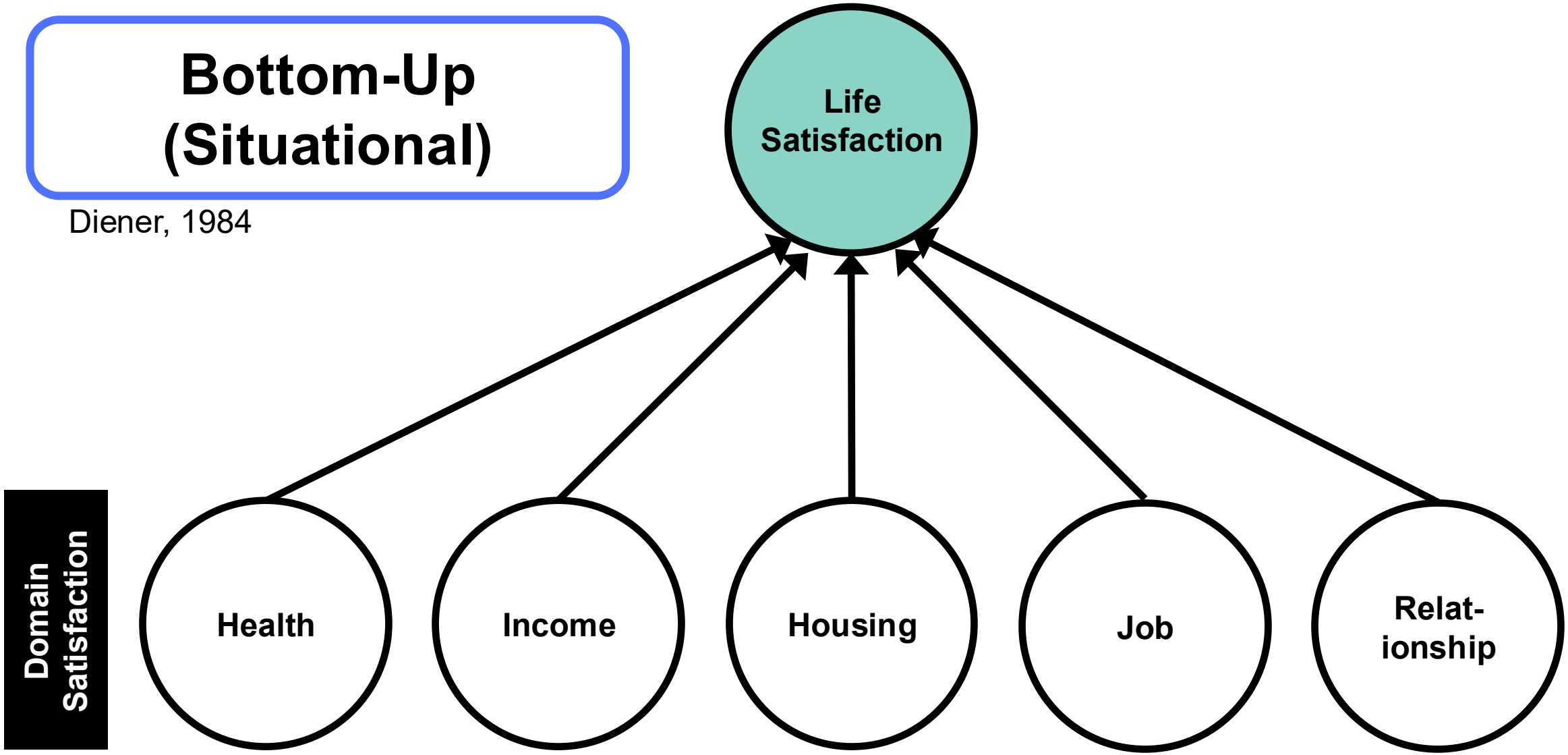


Beck et al. (2025, *NHB*)

Bottom-Up (Situational)

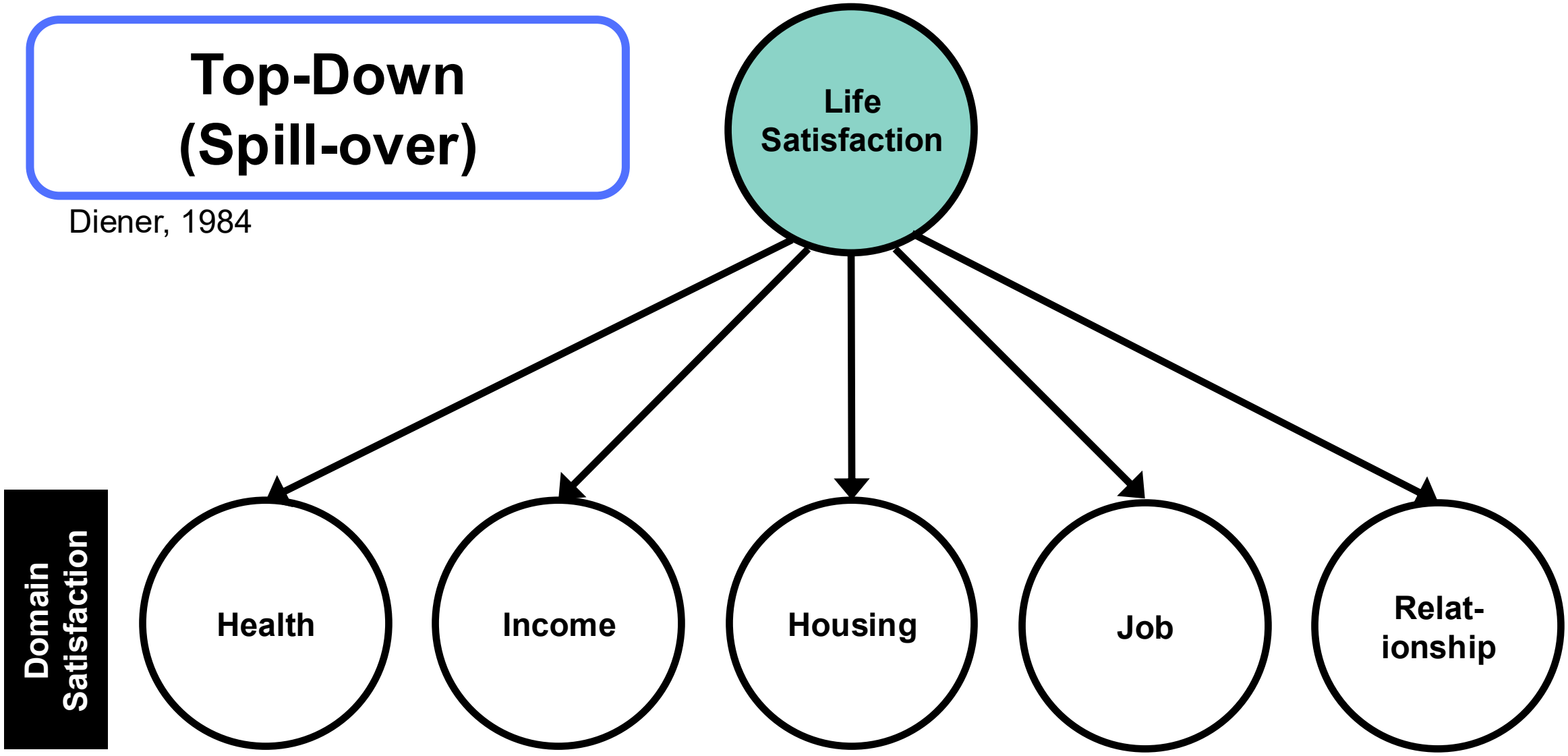
Diener, 1984



Beck et al. (2025, *NHB*)

Top-Down (Spill-over)

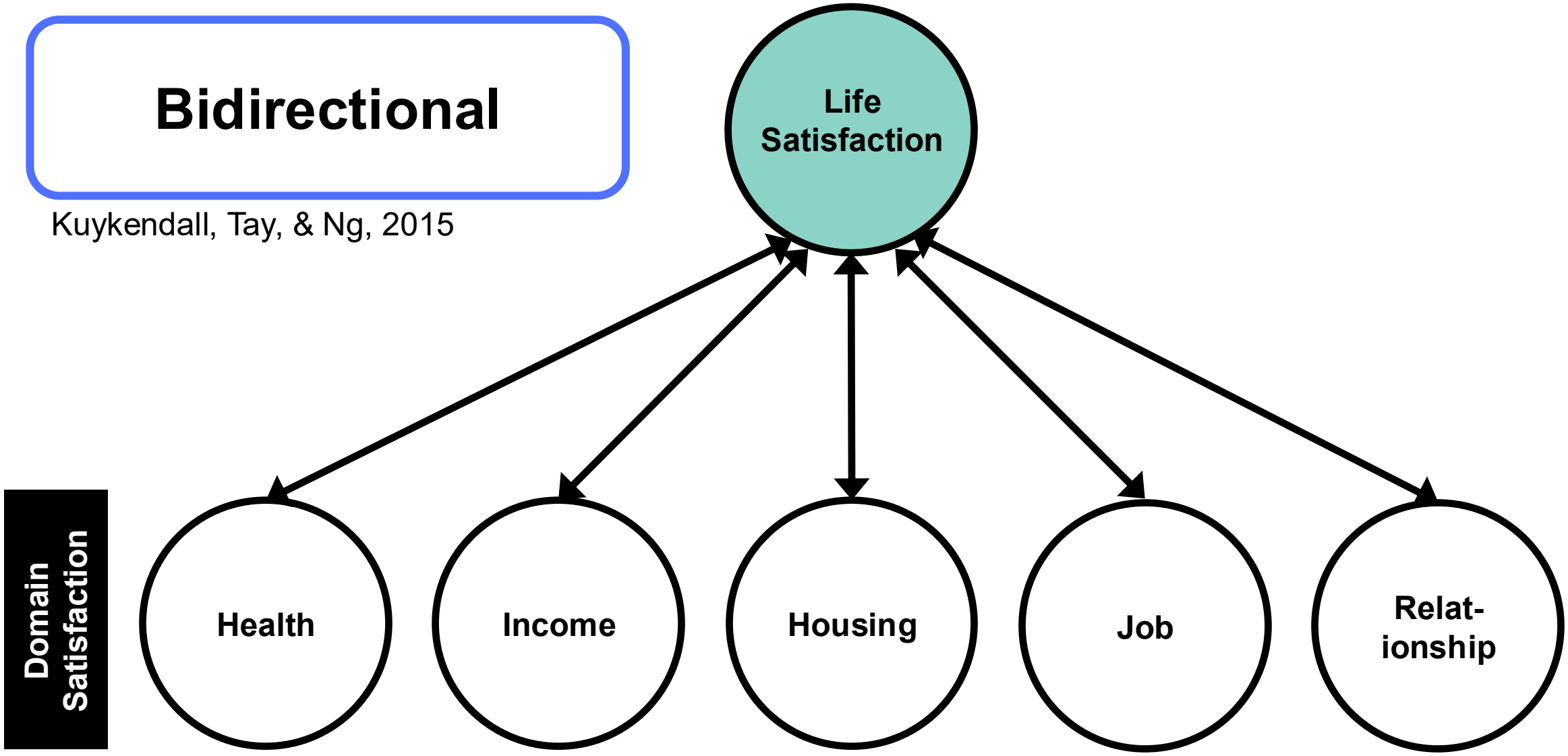
Diener, 1984



Beck et al. (2025, *NHB*)

Bidirectional

Kuykendall, Tay, & Ng, 2015



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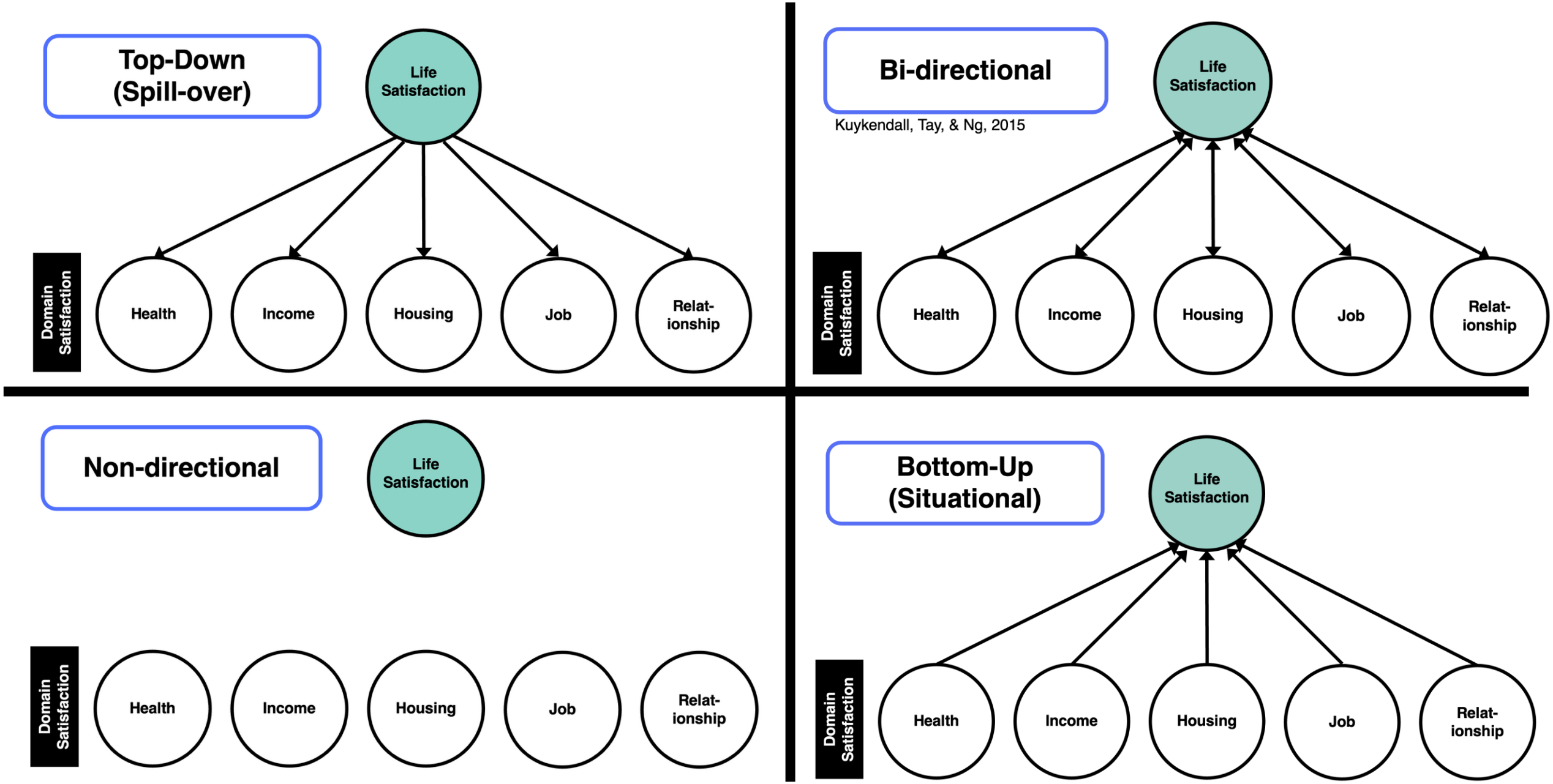
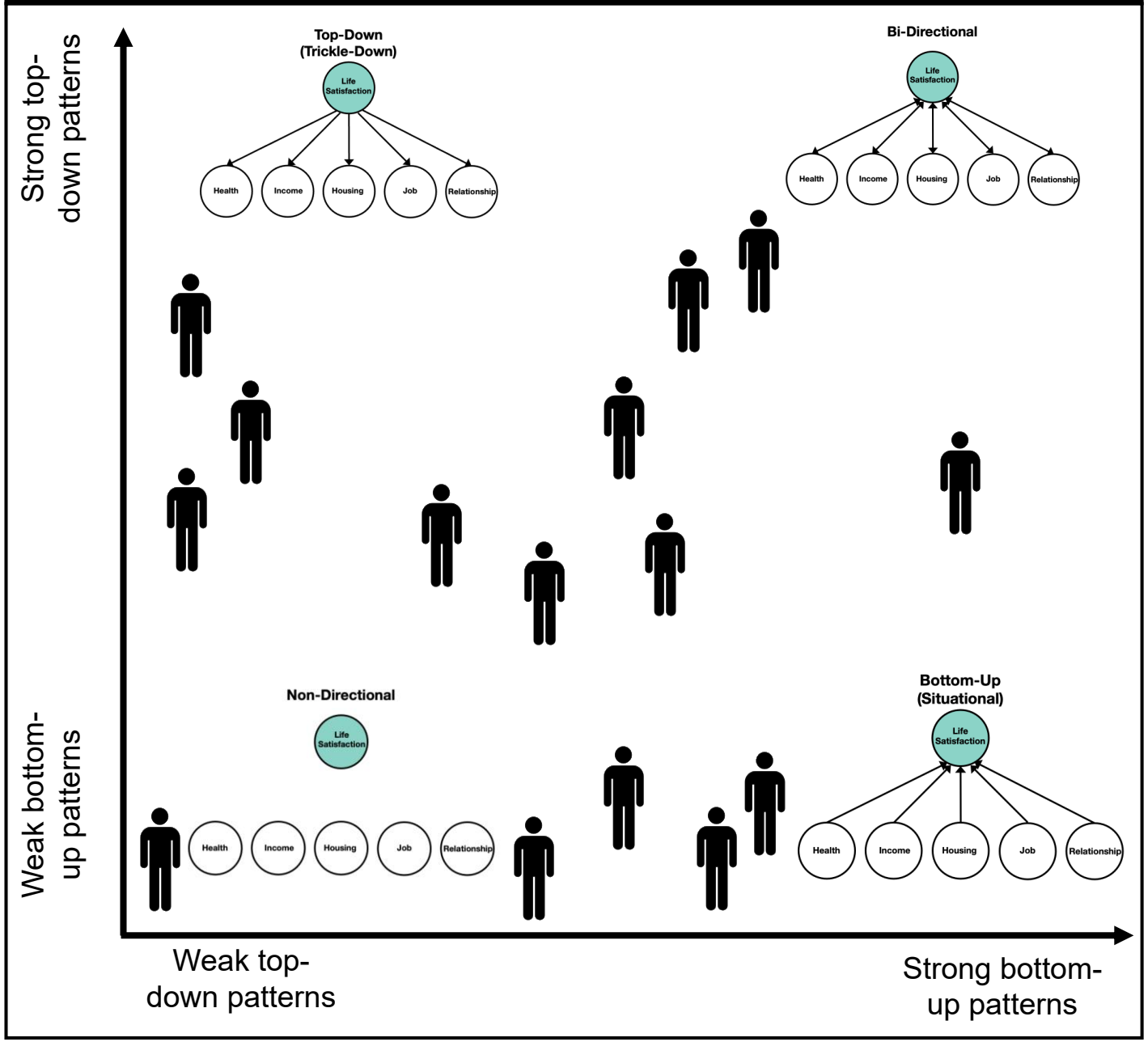


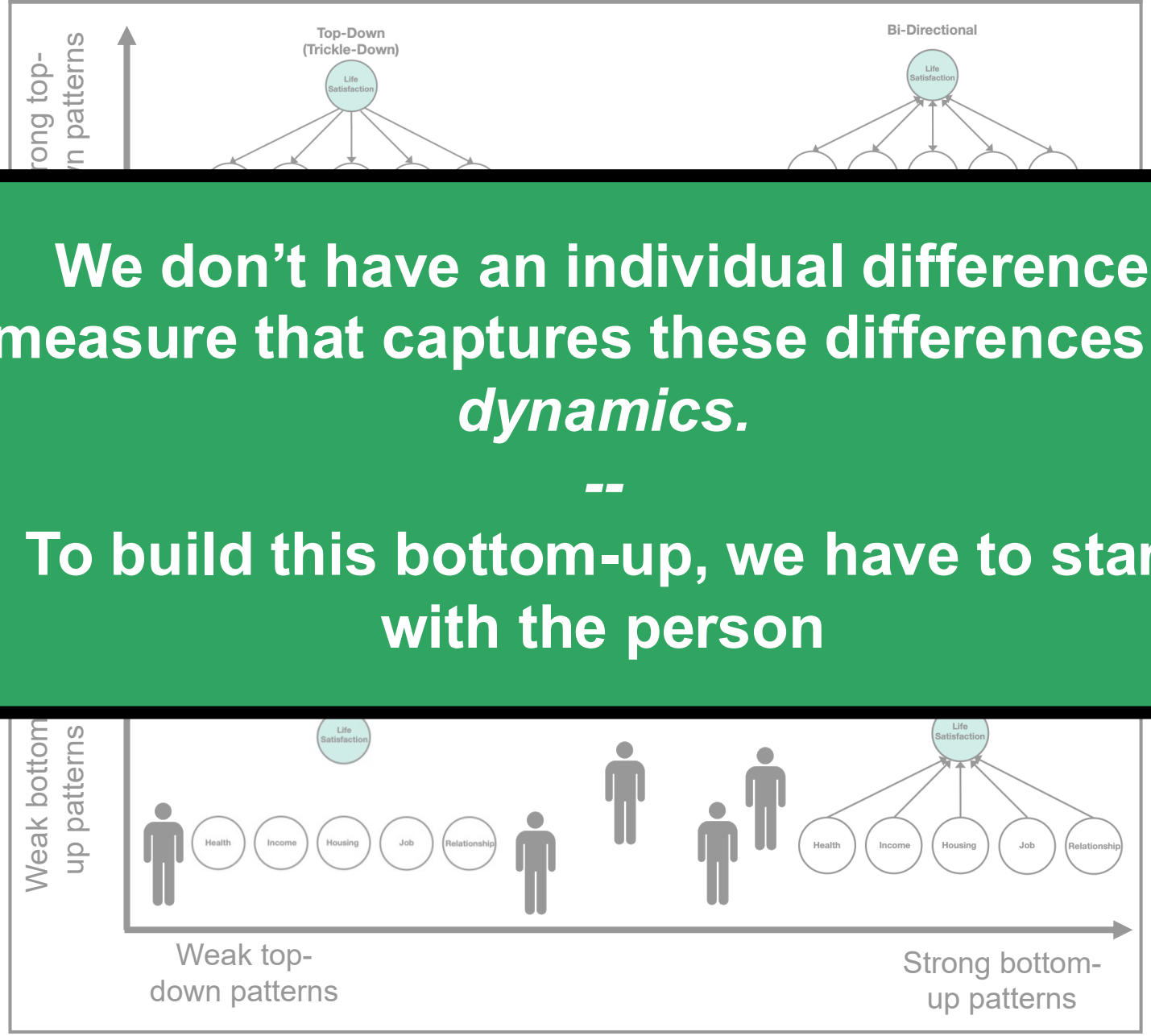
Beck et al. (2025, *NHB*)

Personalised Perspectives on Happiness: For whom is each theory correct?



Beck et al. (2025, *NHB*)

Personalised Perspectives on Happiness: For whom is each theory correct?



We don't have an individual difference measure that captures these differences in *dynamics.*

--

To build this bottom-up, we have to start with the person

Beck et al. (2025, *NHB*)

GSOEP | HILDA | SHP | BHPS | LISS

Multilevel VAR(1) Models

Epskamp et al., 2018

Level 1:

$$Y_{ptj} = \beta_{0pj} + \beta_{1pj} * V_{1,p,t-1,} + \ldots + \beta_{kpj} * V_{k,p,t-1} + \varepsilon_{ptj}$$

Level 2:

$$\beta_{0pj} = \gamma_{00j} + \gamma_{01j} * \bar{V}_{1,p} + \ldots + \gamma_{01j} * \bar{V}_{kp} + r_{0pj}$$

$$\vdots \quad \vdots \quad \vdots \quad \vdots \quad \vdots \quad \vdots \quad \vdots$$

$$\beta_{kpj} = \gamma_{k0j} + \gamma_{k1j} * \bar{V}_{p,1} + \ldots + \gamma_{kkj} * \bar{V}_{pj} + r_{kpj}$$

Between-Person Effects (Level 2)	$\gamma_{01j} - \gamma_{0kj}$
Within-Person Effects (Level 1)	$\gamma_{10j} - \gamma_{kkj}$
Person-Specific Effects (Level 2 random effects)	$r_{0pj} - r_{kpj}$

Beck et al. (2025, *NHB*)

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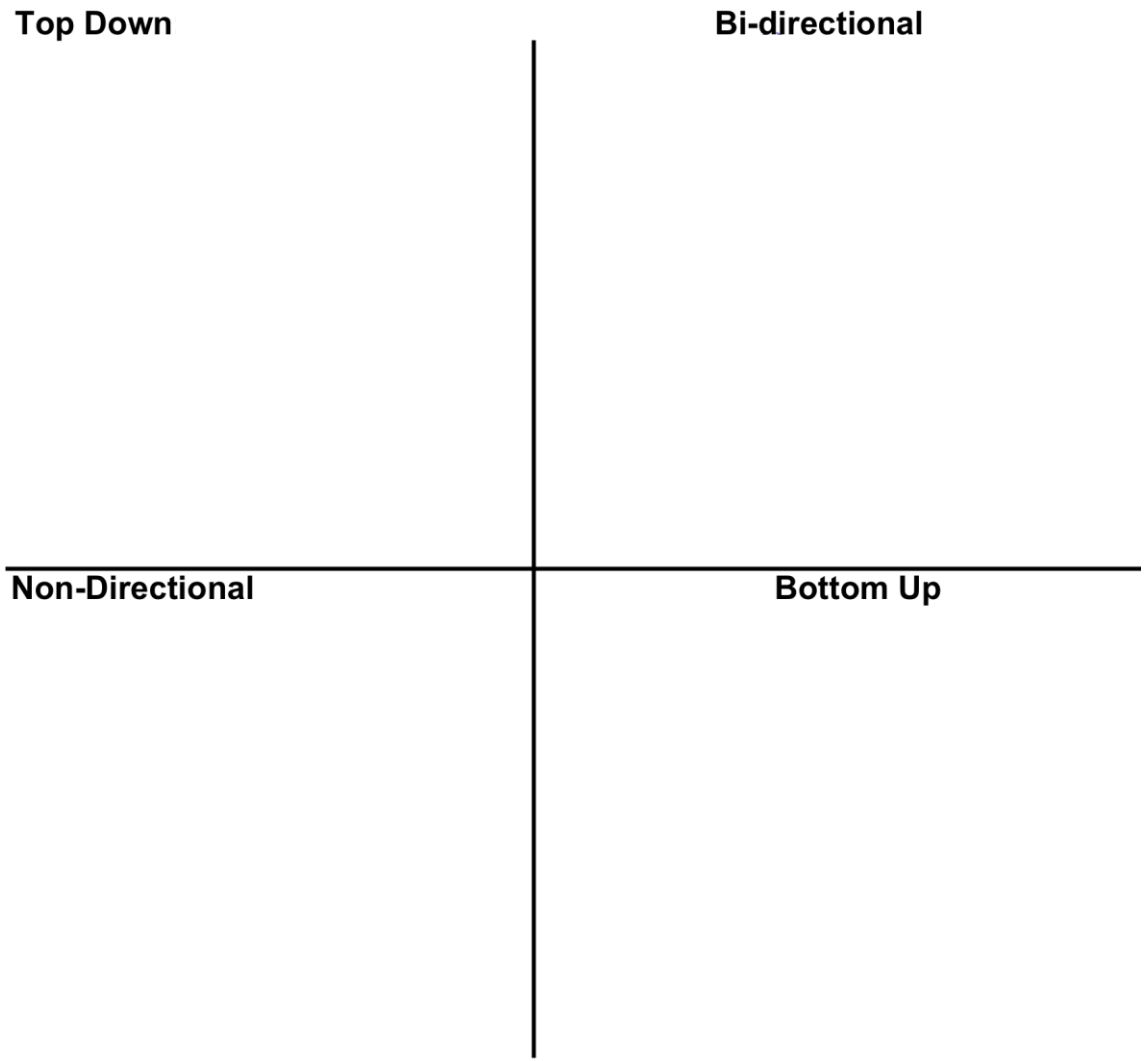
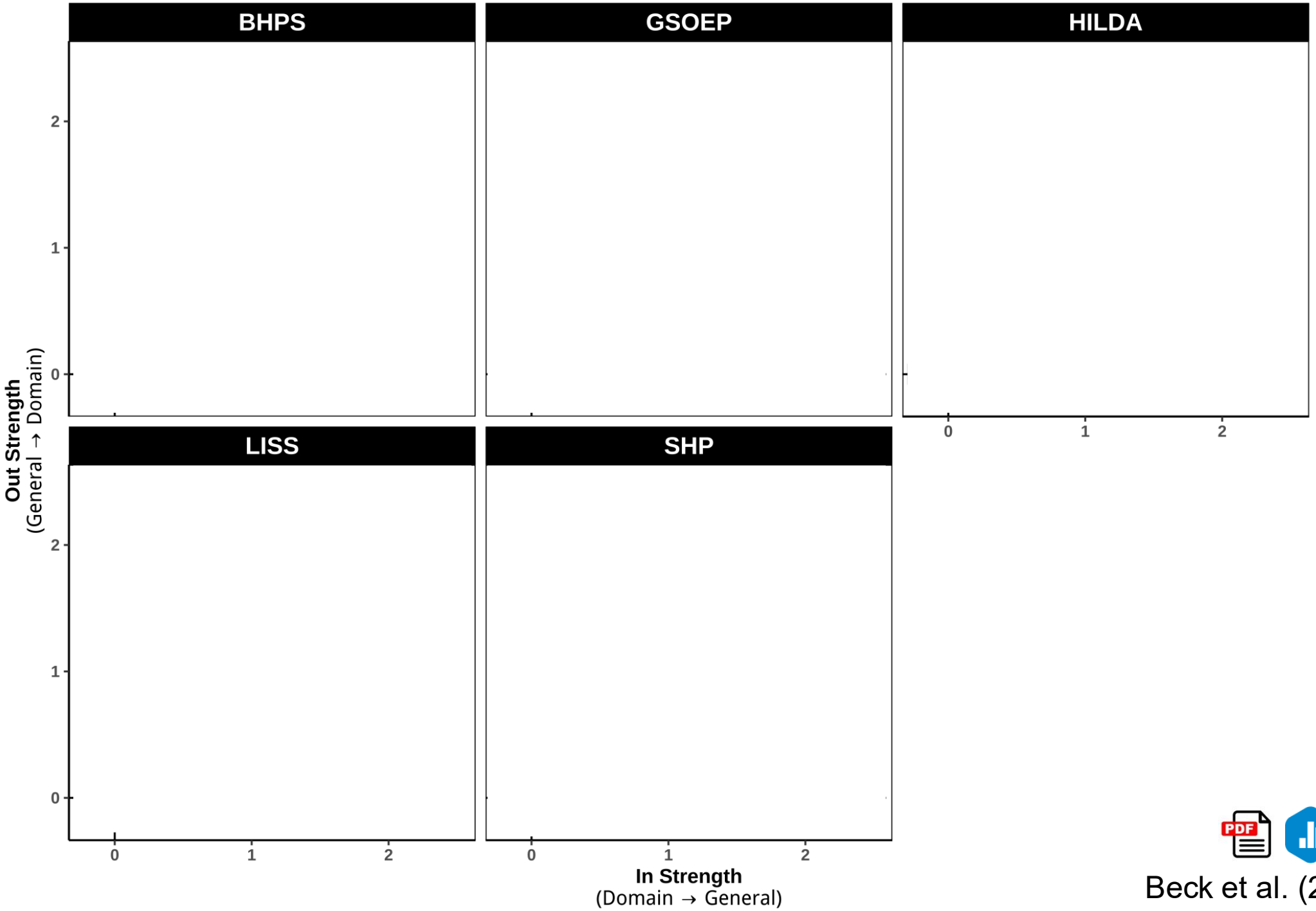
Beck et al. (2025, *NHB*)



Beck et al. (2025, *NHB*)



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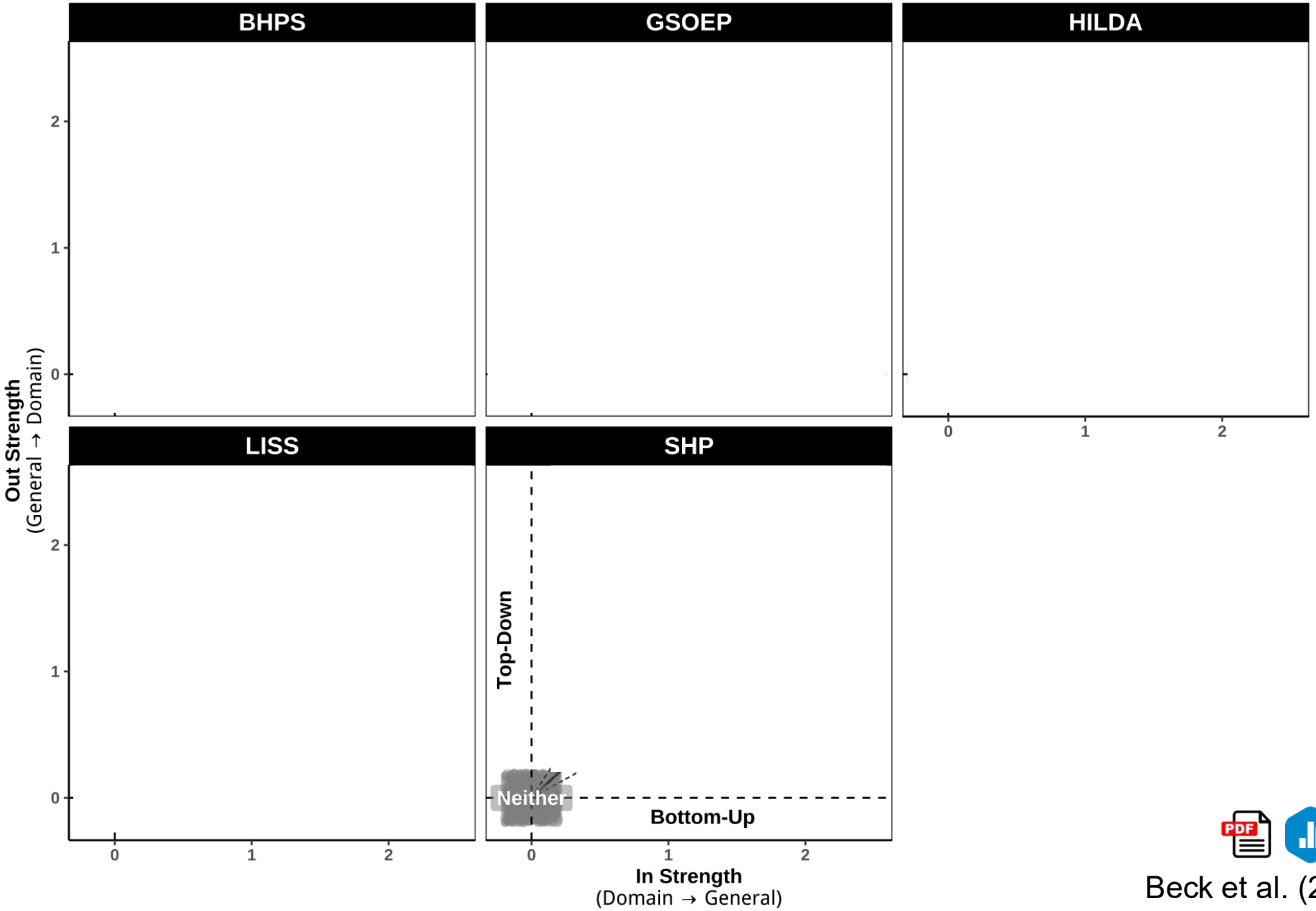

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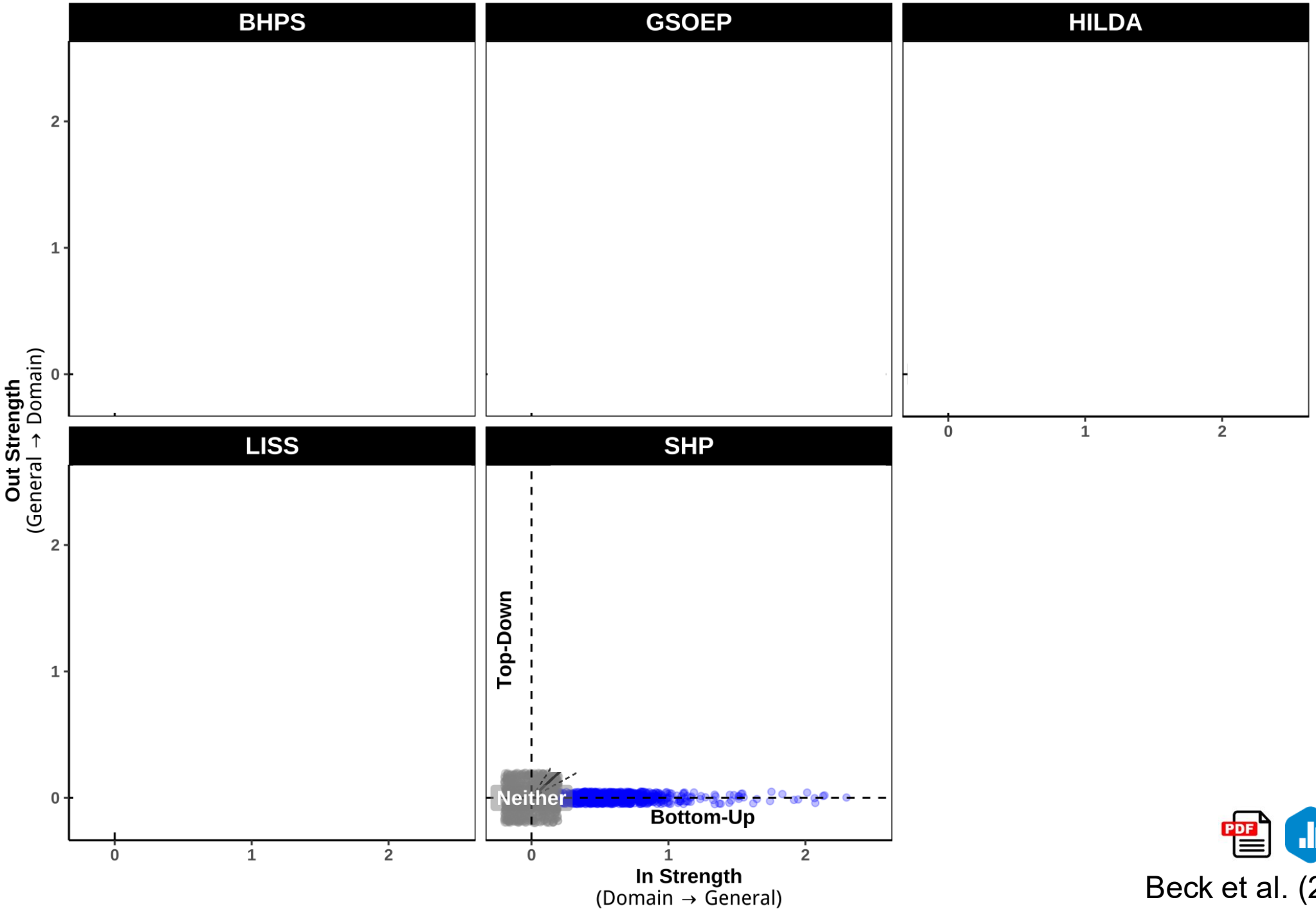

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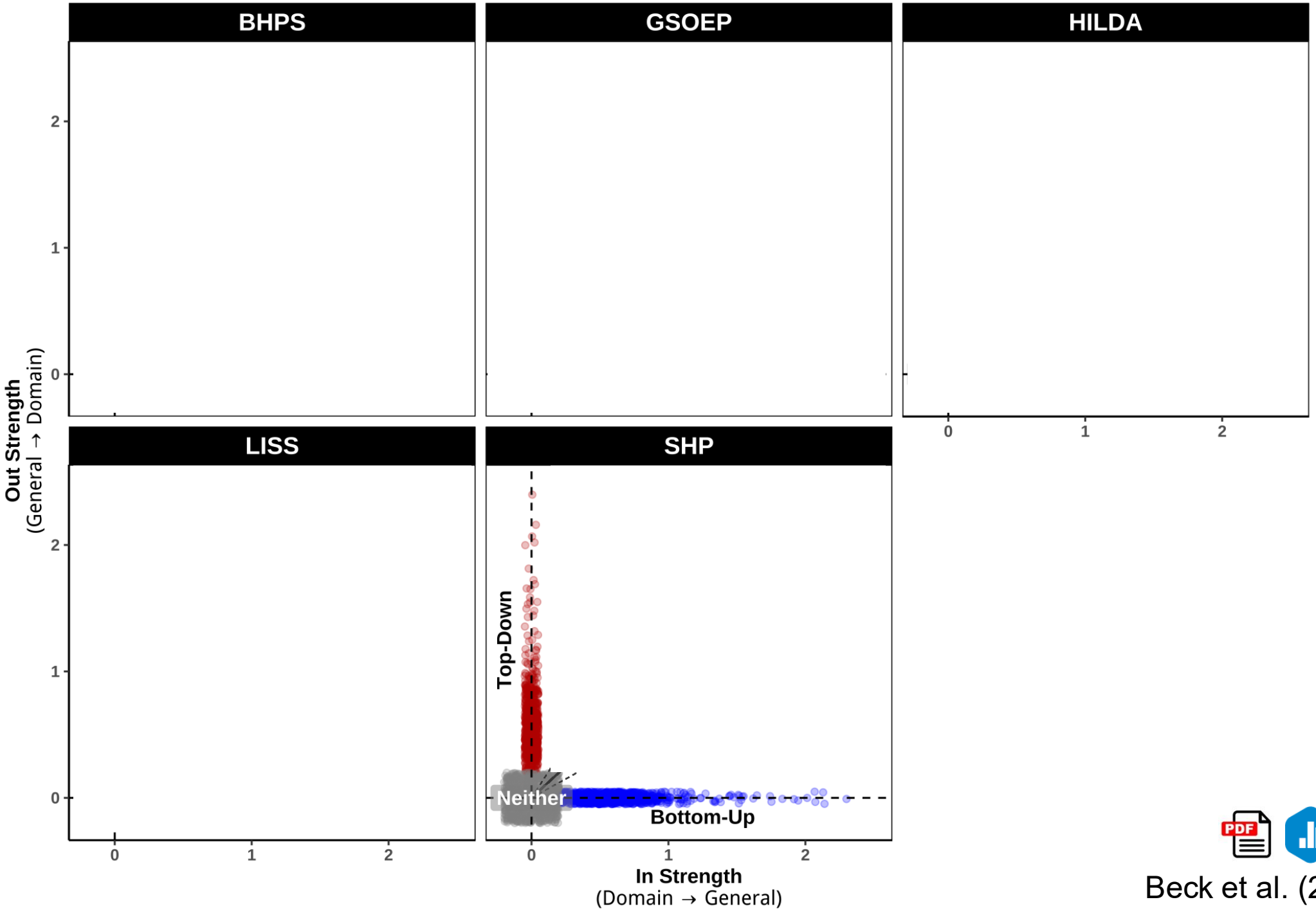

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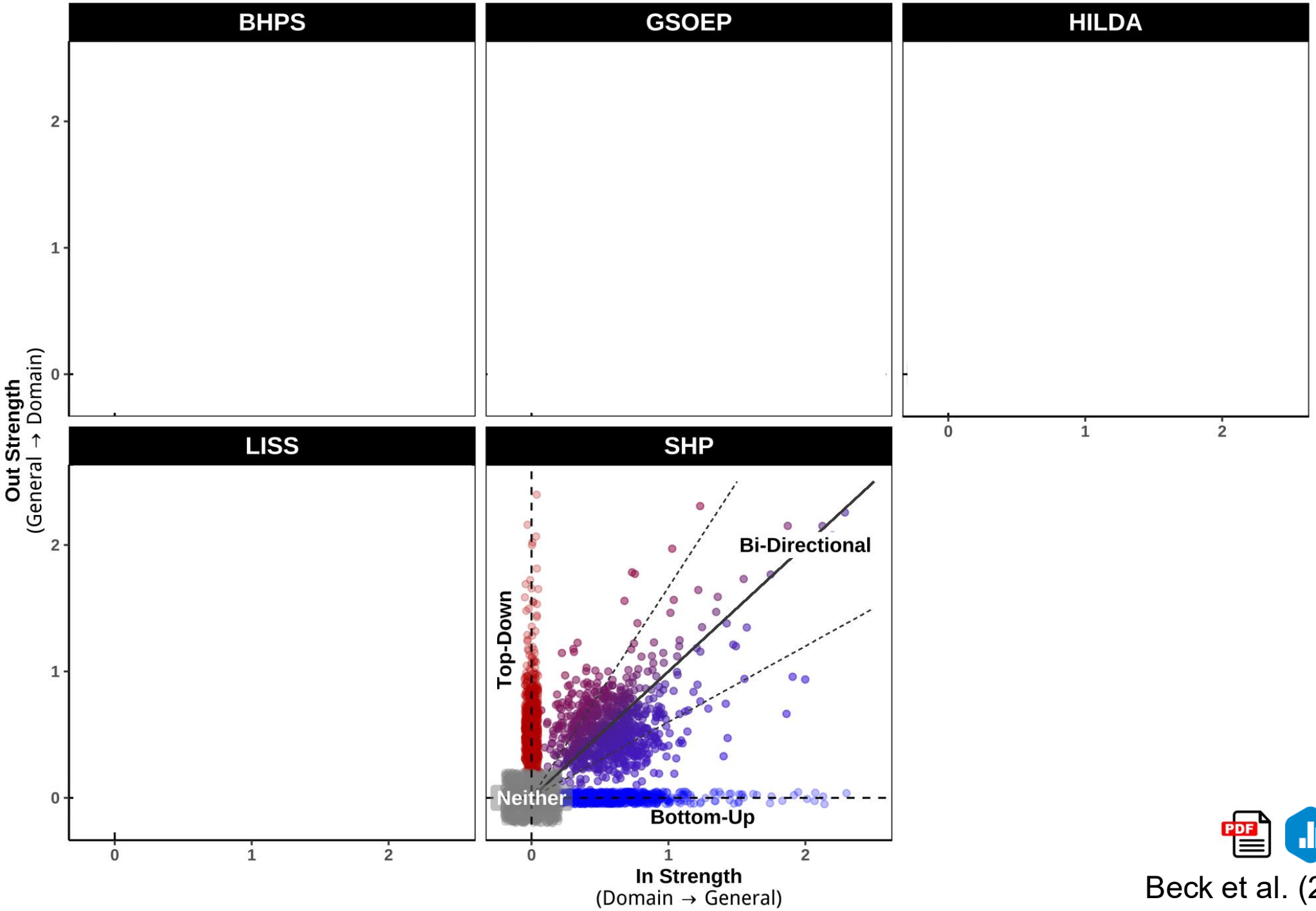

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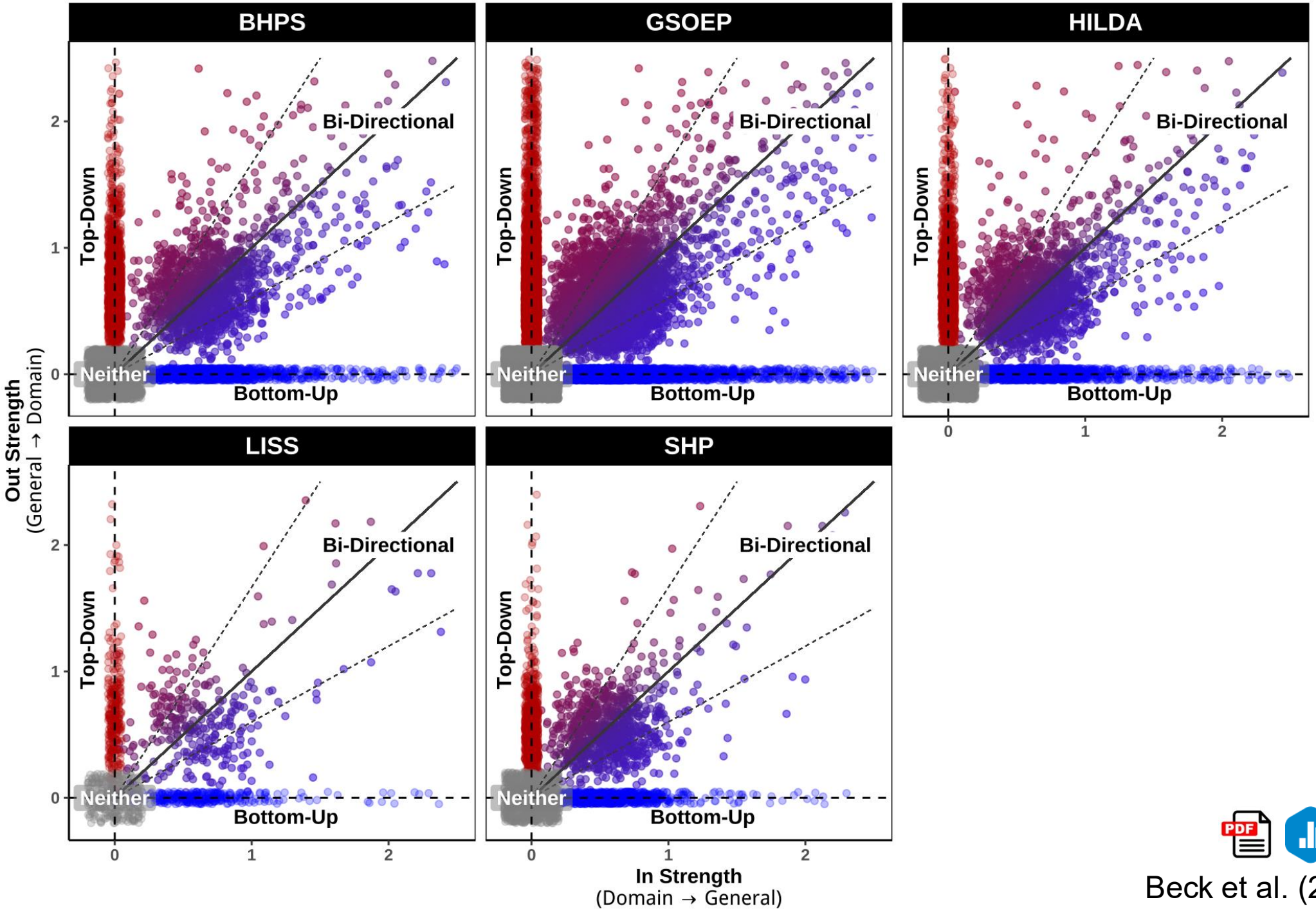

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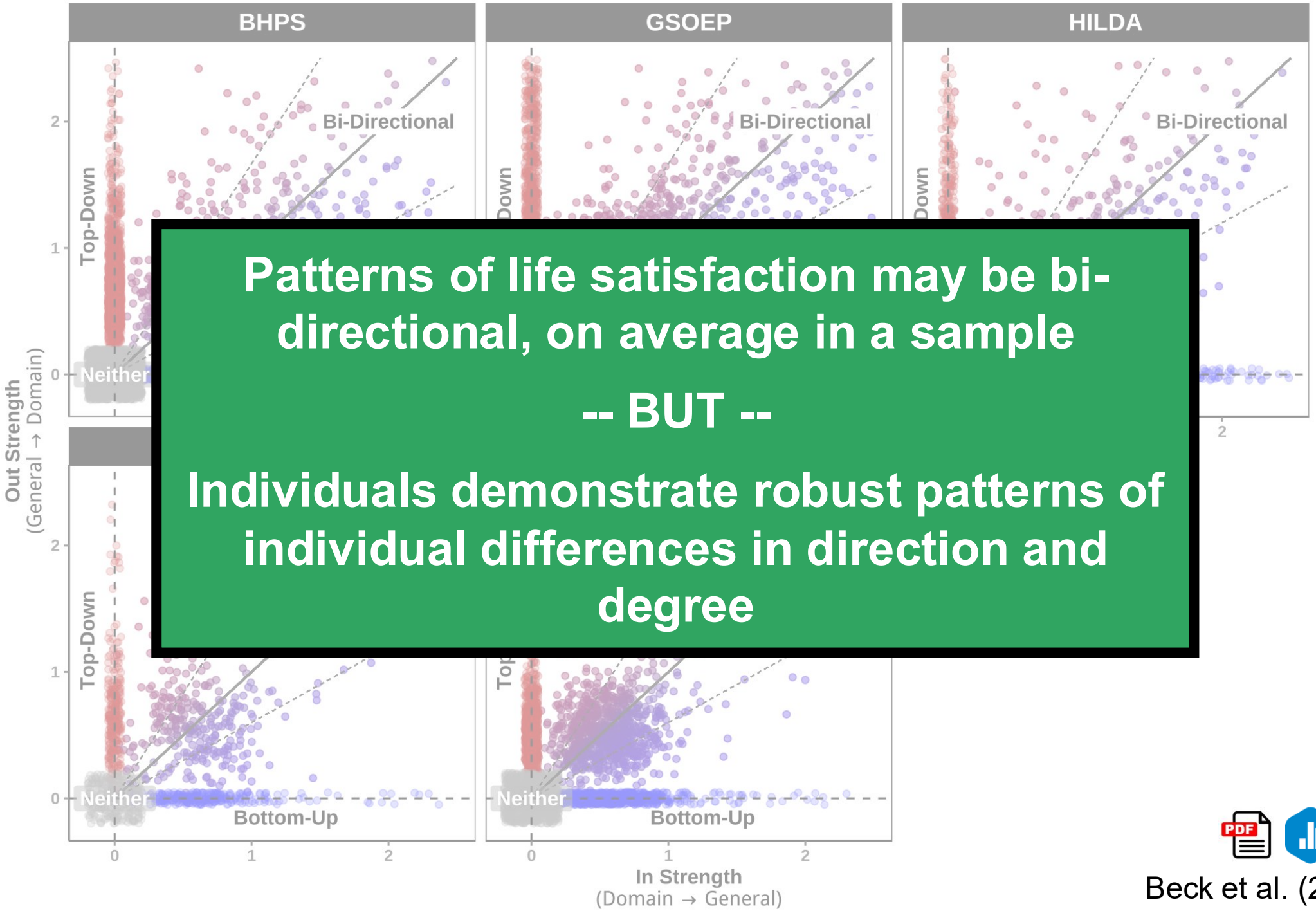


Patterns of life satisfaction may be bi-directional, on average in a sample

-- BUT --

Individuals demonstrate robust patterns of individual differences in direction and degree

Beck et al. (2025, *NHB*)

Outline

Why is the study of well-being aligned with person-specific paradigms?

How does a person-specific approach arbitrate competing theories of well-being?

Person-specific paradigms help us ask not just
which theory is true
but
for whom is each theory true.

Outline

Why is the study of well-being aligned with person-specific paradigms?

How does a person-specific approach arbitrate competing theories of well-being?

How might well-being research move toward person-specificity?

How to move toward person-specificity

Degree of person-specificity

Strict Homogeneity	Population-level effects only; no individual differences (e.g., cross-sectional, simple prediction, multilevel models without random slopes)
Pattern Homogeneity	Population-level effects only with individual differences in parameters (e.g., multilevel models with random slopes)

Liu et al., 2024

How to move toward person-specificity

Degree of person-specificity

Strict Homogeneity	Population-level effects only; no individual differences (e.g., cross-sectional, simple prediction, multilevel models without random slopes)
Pattern Homogeneity	Population-level effects only with individual differences in parameters (e.g., multilevel models with random slopes)
Weak Homogeneity	**Some group-level individual differences in parameters (e.g., GIMME, ct-GIMME, GIMME subgroup; psychonetrics)**
No Homogeneity	**Some group-level individual differences in parameters (e.g., *N* = 1 models, population effects estimated via meta-analysis)**

Liu et al., 2024

Well-Being is a property of a person, not a relative difference in a population

What this doesn't mean:

It doesn't mean that well-being isn't a useful individual difference or linked to consequential outcomes

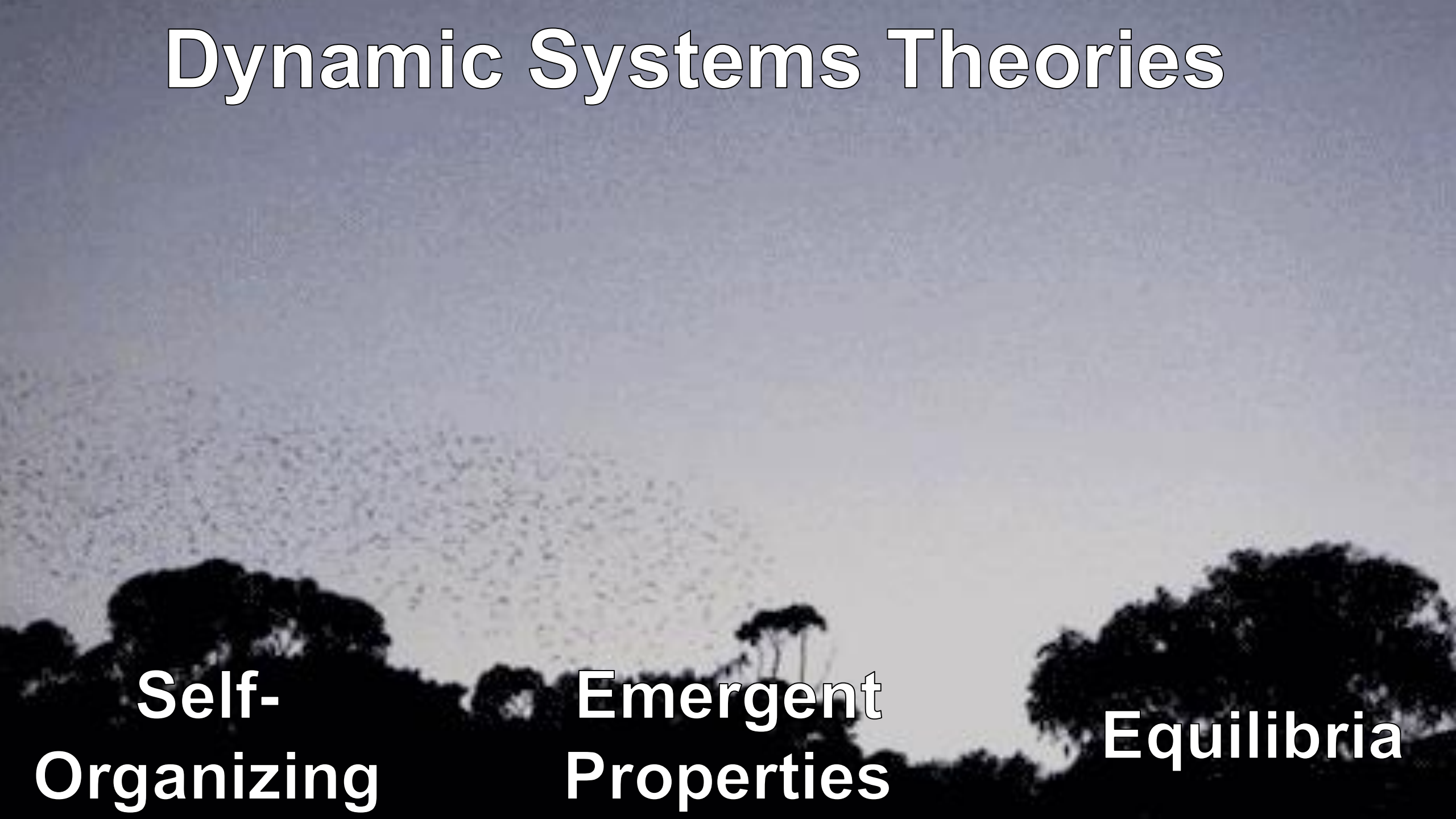
It doesn't mean that we can just sum up "ingredients," weighted by importance

It doesn't mean that some well-being concepts are generally more valid than others

Well-Being is a property of a person, not a relative difference in a population

What this does mean:
Well-Being is a system

Dynamic Systems Theories



Self-Organizing

Emergent Properties

Equilibria

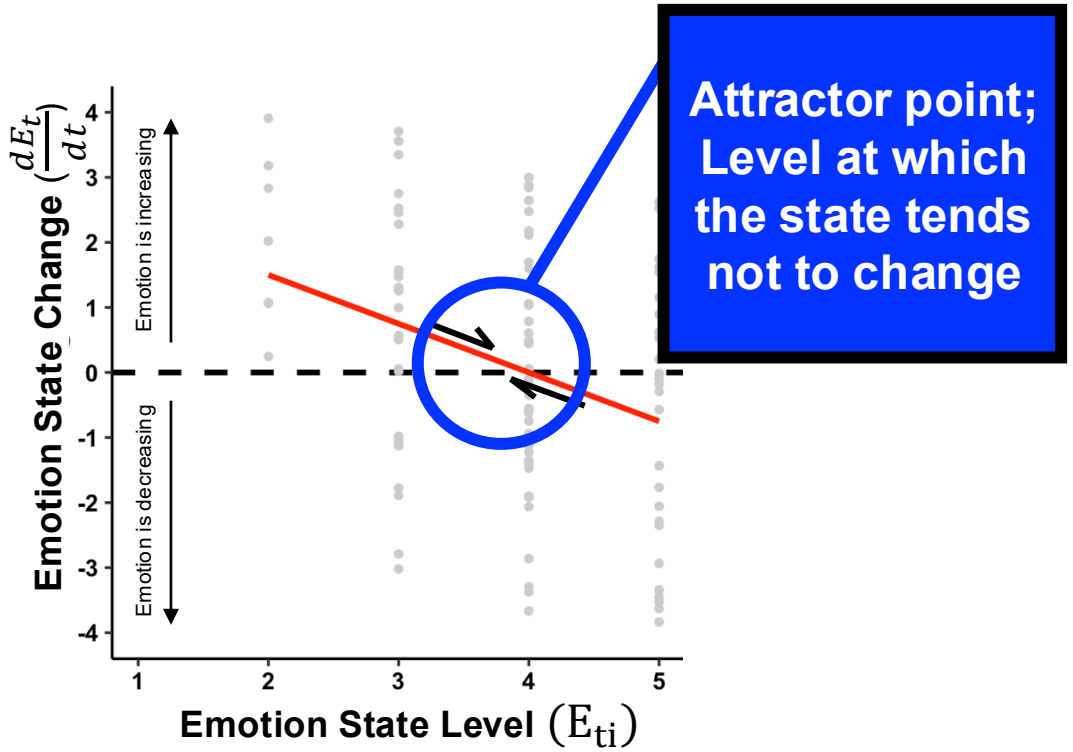
Well-Being Constructs As a System

Looking across individuals, individual differences appear in:

$$\frac{dE}{dt} = b_0 + b_1 E$$

Attractor location
(x at which change is 0)

Attractor strength
(slope; b_1)



Springstein, Batra, & Beck (under review); Lee et al. (in prep); Long & Beck (in prep)

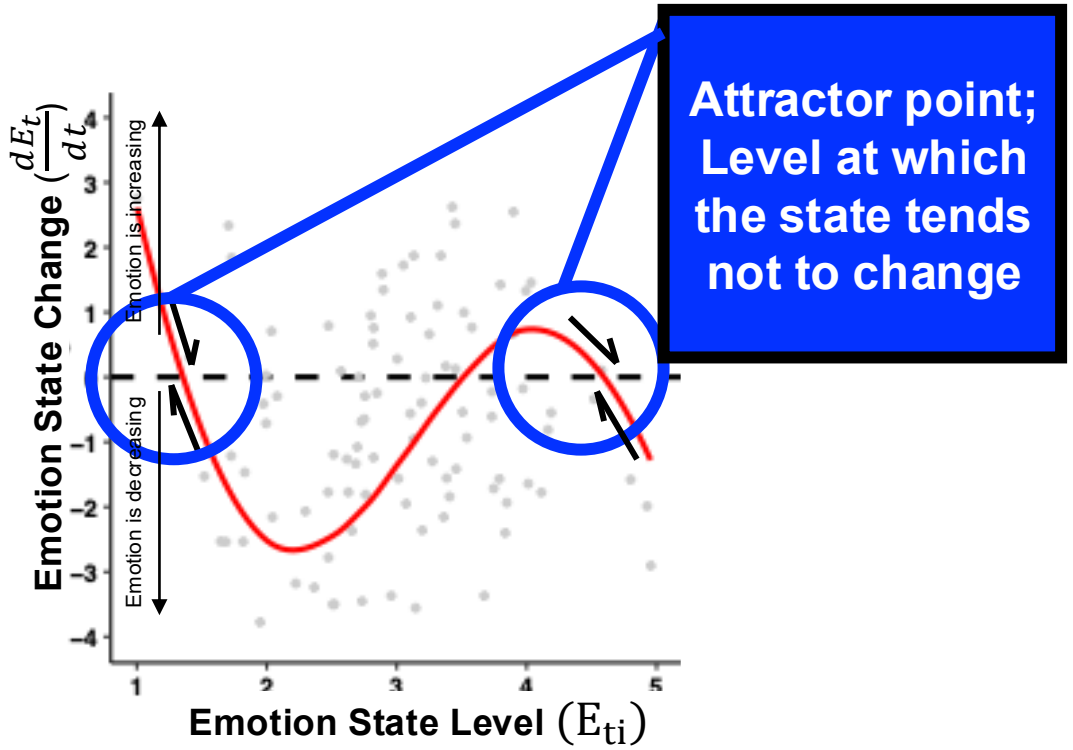
Well-Being Constructs As a System

Looking across individuals, individual differences appear in:

$$\frac{dE}{dt} = b_0 + b_1E + b_2E^2 + b_3E^3$$

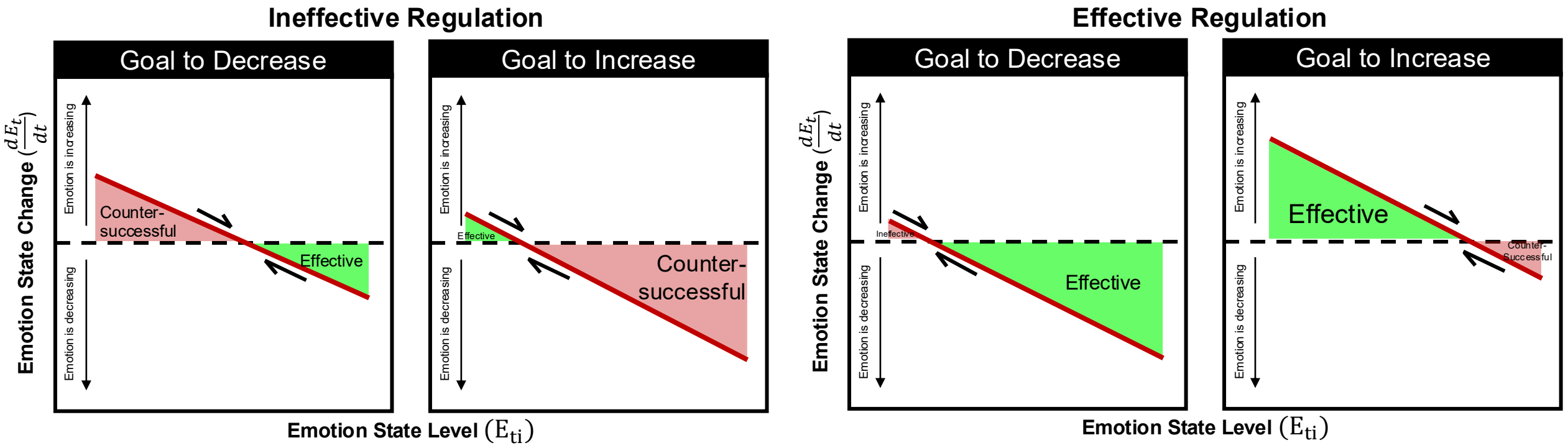
Attractor location
(x at which change is 0)

Attractor strength
(slope; b_1)



Springstein, Batra, & Beck (under review); Lee et al. (in prep); Long & Beck (in prep)

Well-Being Constructs As a System: Regulatory Forces



SCAN ME

Springstein, Batra, & Beck (under review)

Well-Being is a property of a person, not a relative difference in a population

What this does mean:
Well-being measures must be constructed bottom-up

What are we missing when we use the same measures for everyone?

We have no idea. That’s an empirical question!

What are we missing when we use the same measures for everyone?

Content	Variability	Predictive Utility
Hypothesis: People will generate content that doesn't overlap with the Big Five or other typical shared indicators we measure.	**Hypothesis**: People will show more variability and use the full scale more for unique items than shared items, on average.	**Hypothesis:** Unique items will improve predictive utility and play important roles in personalized prediction models.

Well-Being is a property of a person, not a relative difference in a population

What this does mean:

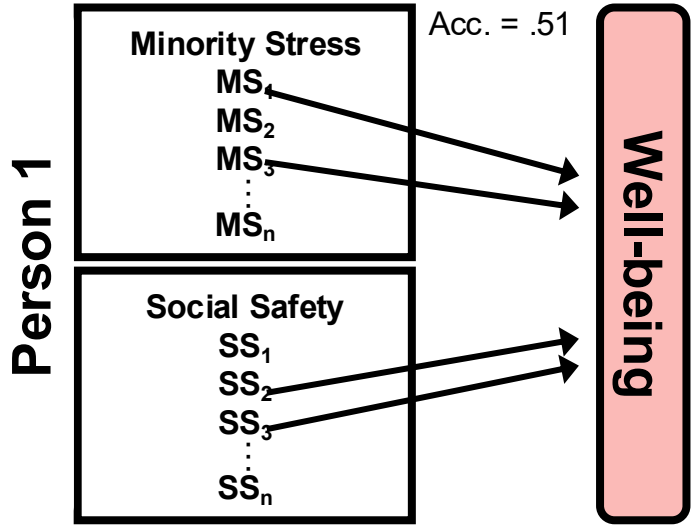
Well-Being is weakly emergent, often indicating multi- and equifinality

What are we missing when we use the same measures for everyone?

Predictive Utility

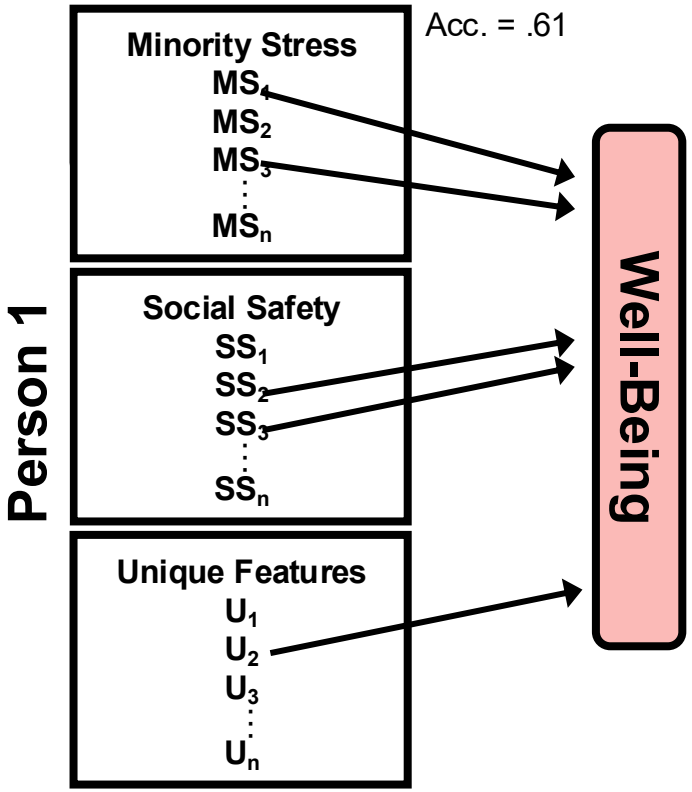
SHARED:

Minority Stress + Social Safety



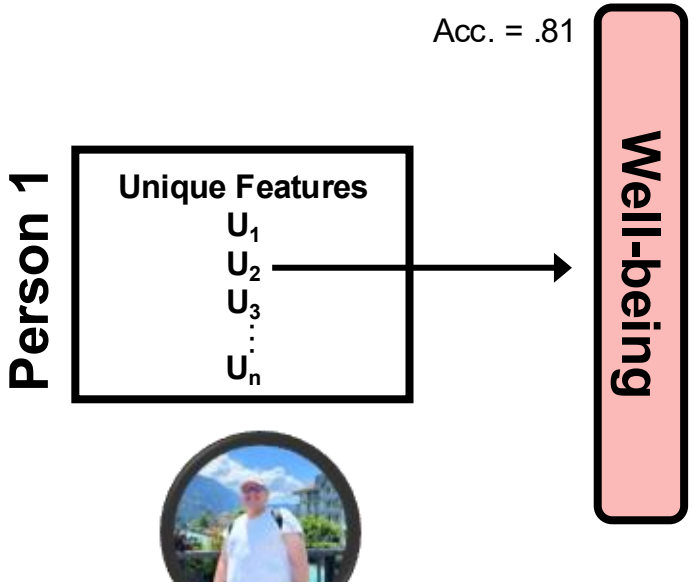
COMBINED:

Minority Stress + Social Safety + Unique



UNIQUE:

Queer Joy



Adam T. Nissen, PhD

What are we missing when we use the same measures for everyone?

Predictive Utility

SHARED:
Minority Stress + Social Safety

COMBINED:
Minority Stress + Social Safety + Unique

UNIQUE:
Queer Joy

Minority Stress

Acc. = .61

Person 1

Which feature set has the best predictive utility?

Well-being

U_3
⋮
U_n

Well-Being is a property of a person, not a relative difference in a population

What this does mean:

Well-Being is a system

Well-Being is weakly emergent, often indicating multi- and equifinality

Well-being measures must be constructed bottom-up

Conclusion

Person-specific approaches capture the complex relationship between the whole and its parts.

Person-specific approaches allow us to ask *for whom* are theories true.

Conceptual and empirical frameworks on dynamic systems paired with multi-method data provide novel research pathways.

Thank You!

Materials & Contact

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bit.ly/joy-is-mine

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Join the Beck Lab!

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